MODULE 31 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

The Revision Gap

Everything AWS changed after exam guide v2.1 - and what to answer anyway.

TYPE Currency MODULE 31 of 34 NOTES 22 across the course

admin@sthithapragna.com

When the documentation and the exam disagree, **answer the exam**. Then know why it disagrees, so you are not talked out of it.

Why the gap exists

- Exam questions are written against a **published guide**, then reviewed and validated.
- That process takes months, so the bank always trails the service by some distance.
- A change announced after the guide **cannot be the intended answer** to any question.
- So a newer fact is never wrong to know. It is simply not what is being asked.
- Most changes **raise a limit** or **add an option**, leaving the old answer still correct.

> ON THE EXAM
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> That last point is why this list is shorter and less threatening than it looks. Very few changes make a previously correct answer actively wrong.

How this course flagged them

- Every currency note opened with **The examinable answer**, stated first.
- Then what changed, with a date, so you can check it against any source.
- Then an explicit instruction: **answer the old value on the exam**.
- They were placed at the point of teaching, not collected at the end.
- That ordering was deliberate. The exam answer comes first so it is what sticks.

> ON THE EXAM
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> If you remember the exam answer and vaguely recall that something changed, the convention worked. That is exactly the state you want on exam day.

Changes that raise a limit

THE EXAMINABLE ANSWER	WHAT IS TRUE NOW
S3 object maximum is 5 TB	50 TB, since 2 December 2025
SQS message maximum is 256 KB	1 MiB, since 4 August 2025
Lambda async payload is 256 KB	1 MB, since January 2026
API Gateway integration timeout is 29 seconds	Raisable to 300 seconds, since June 2024
KMS automatic rotation is annual	90 days to 2,560 days, since 12 April 2024
DynamoDB transactions handle 25 items	100 items, since September 2022

ON THE EXAM

Every row here is safe. The old number is a subset of the new one, so answering the exam value is never contradicted by a scenario built on it.

The one that raises a limit and costs money

- **The examinable answer:** an SQS message caps at **256 KB**.
- Since 4 August 2025 it is **1 MiB**, on standard and FIFO queues alike.
- That removes the usual workaround of storing the body in S3 and sending a pointer.
- **Billing still meters in 64 KB chunks**, so a 1 MiB message is roughly 16 requests.
- The limit moved. The pricing model did not.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Worth separating from the other limit changes because it has a cost consequence the others do not. A larger message is not one cheap request.

Changes that add an option

THE EXAMINABLE ANSWER	WHAT WAS ADDED
ElastiCache runs Redis or Memcached	Valkey, October 2024, now AWS's recommendation
Cognito uses the hosted UI	Managed Login, plus Lite/Essentials/Plus tiers, November 2024
Step Functions uses JSONPath	JSONata and Variables, 22 November 2024
Logs Insights has one query language	Plus OpenSearch PPL and SQL, December 2024
CloudWatch log groups have one class	Plus Infrequent Access, cheaper and more limited
ECS blue/green uses CodeDeploy	ECS native blue/green, 2025
Instrument tracing with the X-Ray SDK	ADOT and OpenTelemetry, now the recommended path

ON THE EXAM

The left column remains correct in every row. The addition is an alternative, not a replacement, which is why none of these threatens a mark.

The rename that matters

- **The exam calls it** advanced security features.
- **The console calls it** threat protection, since November 2024.
- Same capability: adaptive authentication, and compromised credentials detection.
- It now sits in the **Plus** tier rather than being a toggle.
- A rename is the most confusing kind of change, because both names describe real things.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Renames are worse than new features for revision, because searching the current documentation for the exam's term returns nothing useful.

The other renames

THE OLDER NAME	THE CURRENT NAME
AWS CodeStar Connections	AWS CodeConnections
AWS SSO	AWS IAM Identity Center
Application Composer	Infrastructure Composer, October 2024
Amazon Kinesis Data Firehose	Amazon Data Firehose
Cognito advanced security features	Threat protection, in the Plus tier

ON THE EXAM

Exam questions may use either name. Recognising both is the whole task, and none of these represents a change in behaviour.

The change that costs money

- **The examinable answer:** initialisation is not billed for ZIP functions on managed runtimes.
- Since **1 August 2025**, INIT duration **is** billed for those functions.
- Container images and custom runtimes were already billed for it.
- So a slow cold start now costs money as well as latency.
- This one genuinely changes an answer to a cost question, so hold both facts.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Unlike the limit increases, this changes the economics rather than the ceiling. It is the note most likely to make an old answer feel wrong.

Services that closed, and one that reopened

SERVICE	STATUS
S3 Select and Glacier Select	Closed to new customers, 25 July 2024. Still a correct exam answer
AWS Cloud9	Closed to new customers. Not reversed
Aurora Serverless v1	End of life, 31 March 2025. Clusters upgraded to v2
Amazon Linux 2	End of life, 30 June 2026, taking Beanstalk AL2 platforms with it
AWS CodeCommit	Closed June 2024, then REOPENED to GA in November 2025

READ THIS TWICE

The CodeCommit row is why you should be careful with 2024 and 2025 material: a great deal of it confidently describes a service that is now actively developed again.

Why the CodeCommit reversal matters

- AWS closed CodeCommit to new customers in **June 2024**.
- A great deal of 2024 and 2025 material describes it as dying or already dead.
- It was **reopened to general availability in November 2025**, with an active roadmap.
- So it is a live, developed service again, and a perfectly valid source action.
- **Answer normally on the exam.** Nothing about the exam's position changed.

> ON THE EXAM
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> This is the one case where the intermediate material is confidently wrong in both directions. Trust the current position, and answer the exam normally.

The deprecation with dates attached

- **The examinable answer:** instrument with the X-Ray SDK, run the daemon on ECS and EC2.
- On **25 February 2026** the SDKs and daemon entered **maintenance mode**.
- Security fixes only, and **end of support in February 2027**.
- **The X-Ray service itself is fully supported** and actively being enhanced.
- Transaction Search and Application Signals are being built on it right now.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Read the scope precisely. Only the instrumentation tooling is frozen, which is a much narrower statement than 'X-Ray is deprecated'.

Announced but not examinable

ANNOUNCEMENT	WHY IT IS NOT THE ANSWER
Lambda Durable Functions, Dec 2025	Long workflows in code. Still Step Functions
Lambda Managed Instances, Dec 2025	EC2-backed Lambda. Not in the guide
ECS native blue/green, 2025	Real. CodeDeploy remains examinable
CloudFormation IaC generator, 2024	Templates from existing resources
Stack refactoring, Feb 2025	Moves resources between stacks

ON THE EXAM

Durable Functions is the most dangerous row. It genuinely overlaps Step Functions, so a well-read candidate could talk themselves into the wrong answer.

The change still in progress

- **The examinable model:** exponential backoff with jitter, three attempts, standard mode.
- AWS has announced updated retry behaviour, opt-in now via **AWS_NEW_RETRIES_2026**.
- It changes backoff timing, retry quota costs and the DynamoDB defaults.
- It switches **Java, Python, Ruby, PHP, C++ and the CLI** from legacy to standard mode.
- **Default rollout is November 2026.** The principles are unchanged; only the numbers move.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Included because it is the only change on this list that has not fully landed. The exponential-backoff-with-jitter principle is not going anywhere.

The timeline: 2024

WHEN	WHAT
April 2024	KMS rotation becomes configurable
June 2024	API Gateway timeout raisable to 300s. CodeCommit closes
July 2024	S3 Select closed to new customers
October 2024	ElastiCache adds Valkey
November 2024	Cognito Managed Login and tiers
November 2024	Step Functions JSONata. Logs Insights query languages

ON THE EXAM

November 2024 is the densest month, and it lands just before the guide was published on 12 December 2024.

The timeline: 2025 and 2026

WHEN	WHAT
March 2025	Aurora Serverless v1 end of life
August 2025	Lambda INIT billed. SQS payloads to 1 MiB
November 2025	API Gateway REST streaming. CodeCommit reopens
December 2025	S3 objects to 50 TB. Durable Functions announced
January 2026	Lambda async payloads to 1 MB
February 2026	X-Ray SDKs and daemon frozen. June: Amazon Linux 2 ends

ON THE EXAM

Everything on this slide postdates the guide entirely, which is why none of it can be the intended answer to a question.

What has not changed

- **The numbers that decide questions:** 15 minutes, 29 seconds, 5 GB, 400 KB, 4 KB.
- **The IAM evaluation algorithm.** Explicit deny wins, and cross-account needs both sides.
- **DynamoDB key design.** Partitions, hot keys, and the cost of a Scan.
- **Versions and aliases**, and everything built on traffic shifting.
- Almost everything this course spent its time on is in this list, not the previous one.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The stable core is where the marks are. Twenty-two currency notes across thirty modules is a small fraction of the material, and none of it is foundational.

What is likely to change next

- **Limits rise.** Payload sizes, timeouts and object sizes have all moved and will again.
- **Instrumentation converges on OpenTelemetry.** The X-Ray SDK freeze is part of a pattern.
- **Managed replaces self-managed.** ECS native blue/green over CodeDeploy is one example.
- **Fundamentals do not move.** IAM evaluation, key design and the consistency model are stable.
- None of this is examinable. It is for the year after you pass.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Included because a certification is a snapshot and the work is not. Knowing the direction of travel is what keeps the knowledge useful afterwards.

How to revise from current sources

- **AWS documentation is current, not examinable.** It describes today, not the guide.
- Blog posts dated 2024 or 2025 may describe a state that has since reversed.
- Check the **date** on anything you read, and check it against this timeline.
- If a source contradicts this course on a flagged item, it is probably describing now.
- The exam guide itself is the authority on what is in scope. It is short and worth reading.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The practical habit: when documentation surprises you, check whether the surprise is on the timeline. If it is, you already know both answers.

The three that could actually cost you

- **Durable Functions**. A long workflow is **still Step Functions**. This is the likeliest trap.
- **S3 Select**. Still the correct answer, despite being unpurchasable since July 2024.
- **Cognito threat protection**. The exam says advanced security features. Same thing.
- Each is a case where a well-read candidate is more at risk than an under-read one.
- Everything else on the timeline either raises a limit or adds an option.

> READ THIS TWICE
>
> The common feature is that reading current material makes you less likely to answer correctly, which is exactly why the course flagged them rather than ignoring them.

A note on confidence

- Twenty-two flagged changes sounds like a lot. It is **22 out of several hundred facts**.
- Only three could plausibly cost a mark, and you have just read all three.
- The rest are safe: a raised limit never contradicts a question built on the old one.
- Do not let currency anxiety pull you away from the material that actually carries the marks.
- If you are unsure on exam day, answer what the guide would say. That is what is scored.

> ON THE EXAM
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> This module exists so you are not surprised, not so you are worried. The stable core is where revision time belongs.

Every note, and where it was taught

MODULE	THE CURRENCY NOTE
03, 04	Lambda INIT billing. Scaling rebuilt. Managed Instances
06, 13	REST API streaming. Durable Functions, flagged twice
09	S3 objects to 50 TB. S3 Select closed
10, 11	Aurora Serverless v1 EOL. Valkey. The 29-second limit
12, 14	SQS and Lambda payloads. Amazon Linux 2 EOL
17, 18	Cognito Managed Login and tiers. KMS rotation
20, 22, 23	IaC generator. Pipeline V2. CodeCommit. ECS blue/green
25, 26, 27	Log classes and query languages. X-Ray freeze. Retry behaviour

ON THE EXAM

If any row is unfamiliar, that module is where to go back to. Each note sits beside the material it qualifies, which is where it makes sense.

Answer the guide. Know the gap. Do not let the second talk you out of the first.

What to carry forward

- **Answer the exam guide**, which is what the question bank was written against.
- **Most changes raise a limit or add an option**, leaving the old answer correct.
- **Three could cost you:** Durable Functions, S3 Select, and the threat protection rename.
- Lambda INIT billing is the one change that alters the economics rather than a ceiling.
- The stable core is unchanged, and it is where almost all the marks live.

> ON THE EXAM
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> That completes the teaching and revision content. What remains is three practice exams, and the two opening modules recorded last.